We knew, of course, that the Australians were all excellent players, despite being at the receiving end for the time being, and we knew that it was important to keep them under pressure throughout the match. A champion team needs only a small window of opportunity to stage a fightback, something I had learnt over the years. If the Australians were on the back foot, you couldn't allow them the whiff of an opportunity to stage a recovery. We needed to be ruthless and we were. Having scored 633 in our first innings, we let Kumble and Srinath do the rest on a track that was offering variable bounce. Australia collapsed for 181 in their second innings, giving us one of our biggest Test wins. More importantly, we were 2–0 up in the three-Test series against the best team in the world and were justly proud of the achievement.

Third Test, Bangalore, 25–28 March 1998

In the final match of the series our team included a teenaged debutant in off-spinner Harbhajan Singh. I scored a big hundred in the first innings and once again we managed to put the Australian bowlers under pressure. Though Warne picked up three wickets, he also went for a lot of runs. To his credit, he was always in the game, despite being attacked. In fact, as I played out the last over of the first day against him, I had to keep telling myself to concentrate till the very last ball was bowled. A true great, Warne would not let you relax for a single delivery.

Mark Waugh batted brilliantly in the Australian first innings, scoring an unbeaten 153, and Michael Kasprowicz, the fast bowler, picked up a five-wicket haul in our second innings to set up the match. I was caught and bowled by Kasprowicz for 31, playing a ball early, and we collapsed for a paltry 169. There was no doubt about it: Australia had played better than us in Bangalore and had shown what they were made of. For our part, we were disappointed at not closing out the series on a winning note.

It was one of the most intense series I played in my career, and one of the most personally successful. I had scored close to 450 runs at an average of 111. Weeks of rigorous practice had paid off and it was a deeply satisfying feeling.

Pepsi triangular series, April 1998